





writes Amit Khanna in his 2019 book, *Words, Sounds, Images: A History of Media and Entertainment in India*. "Attracting a near-impossible 90 per cent viewership, these shows were commercial blockbusters, earning millions in advertisement revenue." The film industry, it seemed, was content to cede the mythological narrative to television.

From Gods to Gurus

Bollywood, meanwhile, shifted its gaze from gods to 'godmen', probing the power they wield, the influence they command and their capacity to deceive. In Rajkumar Hirani's *PK*, the highest-grossing film of 2014, an alien played by Aamir Khan becomes the vehicle for a satire on religion as a commercial enterprise, with fraudulent babas exploiting faith for profit. He does so by exposing the lies of its antagonist, Tapasvi Maharaj (Saurabh Shukla). Around the same time, some godmen recognised cinema's potential to spread their teachings and turned filmmakers themselves. Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh, head of the Dera Sacha Sauda sect—and now serving a prison term for rape—made four films that put himself and the devotion he commands centre stage, beginning with *MSG: The Messenger of God*.

Chaturvedi is troubled by what he sees as a larger trend of films portraying the "*dhongi paakhandi*" [fraudulent and hypocritical] aspects of religious gurus. "If you see the villains, especially in web series, their *vesh bhusha* [attire], language, you will find them wearing *tilak* and *kalavaah* [a red-and-yellow thread tied around the wrist]," he says. "Why can't a *tilak-dhaari vyakti* [a person who wears a tilak] be a hero of the film?" He is alluding to shows such as *Sacred Games*, *Leila*, *Aashram* and *Hunkkaar: The Roar*, and films such as *Maharaj* and *Sirf Ek Banda Kaafi Hai*, in which godmen are portrayed as sexual predators or shadowy figures with sinister motives. Of late, though, Bollywood is trying to make gods cool again with films like 2022's *Brahmastra* (Shiva).

1. *Chiranjeevi Hanuman*

Director
Rajesh Mapuskar

Producers
Abundantia Entertainment & Collective Artists Network

Date of release
Feb. 5, 2027

Having directed films like *Ferrari Ki Sawari*, *Ventilator*, Mapuskar's next is an AI-generated film on Hanuman, a tale he says is "rooted in deep reverence for our culture, heritage and history".

2. *Shrimad Bhagavatam*

Directors: *Akash & Amrit Sagar Chopra*

Producers
Sagar Pictures Entertainment

Expected release
2027

Known for the beloved *Ramayan* serial of yore, Sagar Pictures kick off a seven-part Krishna-focused spiritual universe adapted from the Bhagavada Mahapurana.

3. *Tera Sai*

Director
Palash Muchhal

Producer
Pal Music & Films

Date of release
Feb. 5, 2027

Cinema's favourite saint gets another big-screen treatment with National Award-winning actor Sanjai Mishra as Sai Baba. Director (and singer-composer) Muchhal sets out to familiarise audiences with his teachings.